MASTER OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION

SEMESTER 1



DMBA114

BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Unit – 2

Types and Channels of Communication

TABLE OF CONTENTS

SL No	Topic		Fig No / Table / Graph	SAQ / Activity	Page No
1	Introduction		-	-	4
	1.1	Objectives	-	-	
2	Types of Communication		-	1	5 - 10
	2.1	Usage of Verbal Communication	-	-	
	2.2	Characteristics of Non-Verbal Communication	-	-	
3	Classification of Non-Verbal Communication		I	2, I	11 - 16
4	Classification of Communication Channels		-	3	17 - 22
	4.1	Selecting the Appropriate Channel	II	-	
	4.2	Comparison of Oral and Written Communication Channels	III	-	
5	Summary		-	-	23
6	Glossary		-	-	24
7	Terminal Questions		-	-	25
8	Answers		-	-	26
	8.1	Self-Assessment Questions	-	-	
	8.2	Terminal Questions	-	-	
10	Case Study		-	-	27 - 28
11	References		-	-	29

1. INTRODUCTION

In the introductory unit, we discussed the communication process in detail and examined each of the elements of communication. The channel or medium of communication was mentioned as one of the key elements. It was pointed out that the selection of the wrong channel can lead to a communication failure. In fact, there is a saying that 'the medium is the message'. This means that the choice of a channel itself can speak volumes, without a written or spoken message. For example, advertising a product in an exclusive magazine conveys the message that the product is of high quality. This unit will focus entirely on channels of communication. The relative advantages and disadvantages of the different types of channels will be explained and guidelines will be offered on how to choose the right channel in a particular business situation.

This unit provides answers to questions like:

1. What are the different types of business communication?
2. What are the different channels that can be used in various situations by a business communicator?

1.1. Objectives

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- Distinguish clearly between the different types of communication
- List the advantages and limitations of each type of communication channel
- Categorise the different channels of communication
- Select which channel to use in different situations, as a business communicator



2. TYPES OF COMMUNICATION

Broadly, communication may be divided into two types, they are:

- Verbal communication
- Non-verbal communication

Let us briefly discuss these two types of communication.

- ***Verbal communication*** **–** This type of communication occurs with the help of words. It provides the opportunity for personal contact and a two-way flow of information. A large part of our communication, whether at work or outside, is verbal. Verbal communication may be divided into two types. They are:

  Oral communication **–** This type of communication may be defined as a process in which a speaker interacts verbally with one or more listeners, to influence the latter's behaviour in some way or the other. Oral communication in a business context can take the form of meetings, presentations, one-to-one meetings, performance reviews, etc.

  > **Example –** In a business context, a manager doing the performance appraisal with an employee or a sales manager making the sales plan presentation to the sales team. In the first example, the manager may point out areas for improvement and in the second case, the sales manager may explain how to achieve new sales targets.

  Written communication **–** This type of communication is correspondence made in writing. It can be handwritten, printed, or typed. For example, a manager is writing a letter of apology in response to a customer's complaint regarding poor service. Written communication at the workplace can take several forms such as letters, memos, circulars, notices, reports, and emails.

- ***Non-verbal communication*** **–** This type of communication may be defined as communication without words. It refers to any way of conveying meanings without the use of verbal language. The game of 'Dumb charades' is a perfect example. Non-verbal communication is generally unintentional, unlike verbal communication. All of us tend to communicate silently and unknowingly send signals and messages by what we do, apart from what we say. Gestures, facial expressions, posture, and the way we dress, are all part of non-verbal communication.

  Non-verbal communication can have a greater impact than verbal communication, since 'how you say something' is sometimes more important than 'what you say'. Although non-verbal

communication can affect both our personal and business relationships, it is particularly important in the workplace. Let us consider the following scenario to understand this:

Your boss has asked you to make a presentation on your suggestions for improving the organisation. You take him at his word and come prepared with an elaborate presentation and a list of ideas. However, as you make your presentation, he yawns repeatedly, sits back casually, looks out of the window, clenches his jaw muscles and begins to frown. At the end of your presentation, he rises abruptly from his chair, says 'thank you for your ideas' in an angry voice and gives you a curt handshake.

In the given scenario, the boss, through his non-verbal behavior, conveys a message beyond the spoken words that he does not really want to listen to your suggestions.

Therefore, while the spoken or written words may be perfect, the non-verbal aspects could convey the exact opposite meaning.

2.1. Usage of Verbal Communication

We communicate most of our ideas to others through verbal messages, i.e., through spoken or written messages. However, verbal messages have some drawbacks such as the message may not be properly worded, or the message may be misunderstood, or interpreted differently from its intended meaning.

For example, even a simple statement like 'let's discuss this matter tomorrow' might be interpreted by one person as 'let's meet tomorrow' and by another as 'let's discuss this over the phone'.

Miscommunication through verbal messages could be avoided by following a few simple guidelines. The guidelines are as follows:

- Avoid words with multiple meanings
- Ensure clarity through highly specific statements
- Avoid overuse of jargon
- Avoid biased language and offensive words. Let us now discuss these guidelines in detail.

Avoid words with multiple meanings

Words sometimes tend to have different meanings in different cultures. Therefore, when communicating in a cross-cultural context, it is particularly important to avoid literal translation of words, since they might have a negative meaning in another culture.

Example – The advertising campaign for Electrolux vacuum cleaners with the slogan 'Nothing sucks like an Electrolux' was introduced without any changes in the American market. However, the

product failed since the word 'sucks' which is American slang, has a negative connotation which means 'bad'.

Even simple words used in the same cultural context could have multiple meanings and be interpreted differently.

Example – The question 'What kind of shape are you in?', might be understood as 'what kind of financial position one is in', whereas the intended meaning might have been 'What kind of mental or physical state are you in?'

Therefore, when communicating verbally, it is important to use words that are precise, unambiguous and have a single accepted meaning.

Ensure clarity through highly specific statements

Instead of describing an object or idea in general terms or in abstract language, use highly specific language to avoid a variety of interpretations.

Example – If you are calling the IT support staff in your organisation to fix a problem with your computer, instead of saying 'My computer doesn't work', it is better to state in more precise terms that 'I get a message saying that my computer is not responding'.

Avoid overuse of jargon

Jargon refers to technical terms or specialised vocabulary. Every profession has its own jargon which only experts in that field can understand. For example, IT experts use terms like 'computer architecture' which the layperson may not understand. The use of jargon depends on the audience with whom you are communicating. A certain amount of jargon may be permissible when writing a technical report but should be avoided when communicating with a general audience, since the terms may not be understood. Most importantly, never use jargon just to impress your audience.

Avoid biased language and offensive words

Biased language is language that makes use of expressions that humiliate or exclude people on the basis of their age, gender, race, ethnicity, social class, or specific mental or physical characteristics. Language has the power to arouse negative feelings, if it is not used with care. This can happen when the words used seem to be objective, but actually contain an intentional or unintentional bias.

Example – Referring to a co-worker as 'wishy-washy' if he/she is not quick in making a decision, could lead to misunderstanding and conflict. Similarly, certain words may have a 'sexist' connotation and be taken in an offensive way. For example, referring to a lady receptionist as 'that female'.

2.2. Characteristics of Non-Verbal Communication

Having defined non-verbal communication in detail, let us now discuss some of its characteristics, which distinguish it from verbal communication. The characteristics of non-verbal communication are as follows:

- Non-verbal communication cannot be avoided
- Non-verbal communication is powerful
- Non-verbal communication is ambiguous
- Non-verbal communication cannot express all messages
- Non-verbal communication varies across cultures.

Let us now discuss more about these characteristics.

Non-verbal communication cannot be avoided

While one can avoid verbal communication by refusing to speak or write, it is not possible to do the same with non-verbal communication. That is because non-verbal communication is not always intentional, unlike verbal messages, as pointed out earlier. Sometimes, silence itself may convey a lot of meaning.

Example – A speaker making a presentation may find that the audience is not very interactive. Instead, he notices people yawning during his presentation. At the end of the session, when he asks for some feedback, there is total silence.

From this example we can say that the audience is bored with the session. The silence indicates that they have not listened to the session and that the feedback is negative.

Non-verbal communication is powerful

Non-verbal communication helps us to form first impressions and make judgements of others. First impressions generally tend to be lasting impressions.

Let us say you go for a job interview fifteen minutes late and dressed in informal attire. When asked some questions, you avoid eye contact. This immediately reflects your attitude and the impression formed of you could be that of a person who takes things casually, is insecure and lacks knowledge.

Non-verbal communication is ambiguous

While precise words can be used in verbal communication to ensure that the message is clearly understood, non-verbal communication is not always clear and easy to understand.

For example, sitting back in a relaxed posture may be a signal of boredom or fatigue. Similarly, avoiding eye contact with your audience could mean that either you are nervous or guilty of something.

Therefore, it is not possible to accurately understand the messages conveyed by non-verbal behavior.

Non-verbal communication cannot express all messages

Non-verbal behaviour can only express a person's feelings, attitudes, level of interest, likes or dislikes for something. Certain messages about ideas or concepts can only be expressed through spoken or written words.

Consider the following example to understand this.

A sales manager wanting to report that sales for the current year have exceeded targets can only do so through a written report or oral presentation. If he is making an oral presentation, his non-verbal behaviour can only indicate how pleased he is about the increase in sales.

Non-verbal communication varies across cultures

While certain types of non-verbal behaviour are universal, others may be different in different cultures.

Examples – There are different rules regarding the appropriateness of the handshake in oriental and western cultures. Generally, in oriental cultures like India, any form of physical contact is not common and is interpreted as being intimate, while it is an accepted thing in Western countries.

Similarly, a nod of the head means yes in some cultures and no in other cultures.

Bowing to your superior is considered a mark of respect in Japan, but is considered unacceptable in the U.S.A.

Arabic cultures use prolonged eye contact to show their interest. But, in the countries of Latin America, this is avoided.

Businesspeople stand close together while talking in Latin American countries, but Western countries find such closeness uncomfortable.

In this age of business communication across cultures, it is important for you to understand these differences, especially when doing business overseas. Failure to do this could lead to costly blunders.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 1

Fill in the blanks:	
1	Two broad areas of communication are _____ and _____ communication.
2	When communicating in a cross-cultural context, it is particularly important to avoid _____ of words
True or False:	
3	Verbal communication is more likely to go wrong in a cross-cultural context. (True/False)
4	Non-verbal communication can be avoided by refusing to speak or write. (True/False)

3. CLASSIFICATION OF NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

We have discussed how non-verbal communication plays an important role in business communication. Given its importance, an understanding of the different types of non-verbal communication is essential.

Non-verbal communication can employ audio and video signals to communicate messages. The ringing of a telephone, the blaring of a siren are examples of audio signals. A blaring siren in a factory can indicate to workers that their shift has ended. By using audio signals, we can communicate with a vast number of people scattered over a large area. Visual signals include posters, charts, graphs and drawings. Visual signals grab the attention of the people. They can be used to overcome linguistic barriers.

There is a common misconception that non-verbal communication is synonymous with body language and includes only body language. The fact is that it is a vast area which has been widely researched and includes several aspects. Table 2.2 lists the different types of non-verbal communication, with the corresponding communication terminology.

Table 1: Types of Non-verbal Communication

Description	Communication Terminology
Body language	Kinesics
Touching	Haptics
Personal space and distance	Proxemics
Use of time	Chronemics
Tone of voice	Paralanguage
Physical environment	Physical context

Let us discuss each of the aspects of non-verbal communication listed in table 2.1.

Kinesics: Kinesics is the most often studied and important area of non-verbal communication and refers to body movements of any kind. Different body movements can express inner states of emotion. The different body movements are:

- ***Facial expressions*** **–** Facial expressions can convey feelings of surprise, happiness, anger and sadness. Let's look at an earlier example. If you meet a long-lost friend and say, "I am very happy to meet you again", but with a sad facial expression, it conveys the exact opposite meaning.
- ***Eye movements*** **–** The eye movements such as wide-open pupils express feelings of surprise, excitement or even fear. The importance of eye contact with one's audience was pointed out earlier. Direct eye contact is an indication of intensity and interest, while lack of it can convey feelings of nervousness and guilt. As prolonged eye contact can intimidate people, it is not a good idea to stare at people. Different cultures perceive eye contact differently. In Asia, Latin America and Africa, people avoid direct eye contact to show respect. Arabs use prolonged eye contact to measure trustworthiness.
- ***Gestures*** **–** Gestures such as movement of the hands while giving a lecture or presentation indicate a high level of involvement in what you are saying. On the other hand, shuffling the feet is a sign of nervousness and speaking with one's hands in one's pockets is considered casual or rude.
- ***Head movements*** **–** The head movements like nodding the head can convey interest, appreciation, agreement or understanding.
- ***Posture*** **–** Posture refers to carriage or attitude. Our posture can indicate our feelings. In formal settings such as job interviews or classroom settings, it is essential that you maintain an erect posture to convey that you are attentive, since slouching or a relaxed posture conveys a casual attitude. Similarly, crossing your arms and legs can convey that you are defensive and rigid. Uncrossing your arms and legs can indicate that you are willing to listen.
- ***Physical appearance*** **–** Our outward appearance, including the way we dress and the jewellery and make-up that we wear can convey an impression of formality or informality. Going to a job interview in casual wear or not sticking to a stipulated dress code at the workplace can convey that you are a rebel, non-conformist or a very casual person.

Therefore, it is important to take care of your appearance, so that you convey the right meaning to others.

Haptics: Haptics refers to communication through touch. We can use touch to communicate affection, assurance, familiarity, comfort, sympathy and other emotions. Touching can also be interpreted as an assault. Hence, we must use touch as a communication tool carefully. Touching is used for the following purposes:

- ***Working*** **–** Professionals such as doctors, dentists, hairdressers and airport security staff need to touch people in the normal course of their work.
- ***Greeting*** **–** Contact through touch is part of the greeting ritual. We often use handshakes to greet people. Retaining contact for a greater duration of time can convey feelings of friendship or domination. In some cultures, people also embrace or rub noses to greet people.
- ***Establishing friendships*** **–** A friendly part or a comforting touch can help in establishing amicable relationships.
- ***Guiding*** **–** A touch on the back, shoulder or arm can help to guide people in the correct direction.
- ***Managing interactions*** **–** Touching is used to manage interactions. We can gently touch the shoulder or arm to gain the attention of a person.

The importance given to touch varies with culture. Asian cultures forbid displays of affection. Hence, touching is not encouraged in such cultures. Cultures like that of Germany and England, have rigid status structures and hence give lesser importance to touching when compared to the countries in Middle East and Latin America.

Proxemics: Proxemics is derived from the word 'proximity' or closeness and is the communication term for personal space and distance. The space and distance which we choose to keep from people is also part of non-verbal communication. Each of us has our own inner and outer circles, which differ for different people. The different types of spaces are as follows:

- ***Intimate space*** **–** Our innermost circle is an 'intimate space', into which we generally admit only select people such as family and close friends.
- ***Personal space*** **–** A 'personal space' might include other friends and colleagues or co-workers. Intimate and personal spaces involve communication of an informal nature.
- ***Social and public space*** **–** The 'social and public space' includes official or workplace relationships, where communication is more of a formal nature.

In a business context, it is more relevant to understand the concept of the following spaces:

- ***Fixed space*** **–** Fixed space means that the physical features of the work environment such as furniture, room size and seating arrangement are permanent. This conveys an impression of formality.
- ***Semi-fixed space*** **–** Semi-fixed space means that certain elements of the environment can be changed. For example, changing the seating arrangement conveys an impression of informality.

Sometimes, use of space at the workplace can determine leadership positions. For example, seating at the head of the table conveys leadership or authority. A round table meeting, however, conveys the idea of equality, since no one can be seated at the head of the table. All points of a circle are the same. That is why when heads of state meet (as in UN Security Council meetings), it is always a round table discussion, since all heads are equal.

Space should therefore be used carefully in a work environment, so as to convey the right impressions.

Chronemics: Chronemics refers to the study of usage of time. This includes our attitudes towards punctuality and willingness to wait. It also deals with the manner in which we structure our time and interactions. Perception of the importance of time varies between individuals and cultures.

For example, in most Western cultures, punctuality is considered important. Arriving late for a business meeting is inexcusable. In other cultures, it is more relaxed, and time is not given that much of importance.

We convey messages to others through the time we spend on a work-related activity or by the importance that we give to time. Arriving early at work or for a job interview shows interest, involvement and seriousness. Spending time with employees and giving them suggestions on how to improve their performance shows interest and involvement in their career growth.

Paralanguage: Para means 'like' or 'similar to', therefore paralanguage means 'like language'. Of all the forms of non-verbal communication, paralanguage is closest to verbal communication. It refers to the tone of voice with which something is said. In other words, it is 'how' something is said, and not 'what' is said. The tone of voice includes the pitch (high or low pitch), the pace (slow or fast) the emphasis on words and the volume (soft or loud) and can convey different moods and emotions.

For example, the statement, "I practice good business communication." can be understood in different ways, depending on the emphasis on certain words. When more emphasis is given to 'I' while saying "I practice good business communication." means that the speaker alone practices it above anyone else. On the other hand, placing more emphasis on 'practice good business communication' could be interpreted to mean that the speaker communicates particularly well in a business context, rather than in a general context.

The important point to keep in mind regarding tone of voice is to avoid mixed signals - that is, making sure that what you say is consistent with how you say it.

Physical context: Physical context refers to the physical environment or surroundings within which we communicate. This includes the following aspects:

- ***Colour and layout*** **–** Colours are known for their symbolic meaning and have associations with different feelings. For example, colours like black and grey are associated with death, mourning and negative feelings. Yellow and green are associated with more positive feelings. Of course, these can also vary across cultures. The point to remember is that you can make the right impressions with use of the right colours. Layout in a work environment refers to the size of an office, or the arrangement of furniture.
- ***Design*** **–** Design refers to the type of chairs, desks or carpeting. All these can convey status, formality or informality.
- ***Space management*** **–** Space management refers to the arrangement of workspaces of people who regularly work together. It can influence employee interactions and enable effective communication. It includes the size and sequence of offices, the length and width of hallways, the arrangement of the meeting rooms, etc.
- ***Location*** **–** The location in which we communicate influences the manner and nature of communication. Communication done from a podium to a vast audience needs to be loud. The same form of communication cannot be done in a meeting room. The actual location of the office space communicates status. An office in a city's business district conveys greater success in business than in the suburbs.
- ***Distance*** **–** The physical distance between the people communicating influences the nature of communication. Virtual offices or communicating with long-distance partners requires different forms of communication like telephone messages, videoconferencing, e-mail etc.

We have discussed how the types of non-verbal communication outnumber the types of verbal communication. Non-verbal communication is an important supplement to verbal communication and can enhance verbal communication, if used in a positive way. The sender should use the right non-verbal cues to convey a positive message, while the receiver should learn to look for unintended messages conveyed by non-verbal communication.

Activity - 1

Observe a person with whom you work or interact regularly and note down the messages (both positive and negative) that he/she conveys through his/her nonverbal behaviour in terms of a) Tone of voice b) Dress c) Body language and d) Use of personal space and distance.

(Refer section 2.3 for detailed guidelines.)

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 2

Match the Following:	
5	Set A A. Nodding the head B. Time language C. A boss visiting an employee's office for discussion D. An executive chair and a carpeted room E. Speaking loudly Set B 1. Paralanguage 2. Kinesics 3. Arriving late for a meeting 4. Personal space and distance 5. Physical context
Fill in the Blanks:	
6	Use of space at the workplace can determine _____ positions.
7	Colours are known for their symbolic meaning and have associations with different _____.
True or False:	
8	Yellow and green are associated with negative feelings. (True/False)

4. CLASSIFICATION OF COMMUNICATION CHANNELS

We have discussed two broad types of communication – verbal and non-verbal, in detail. We will now examine the choice of channels for different business situations.

As a business communicator, within oral and written communication, you will have a choice of a variety of channels through which to deliver your message. Oral communication could take place through a face-to-face meeting, telephone or teleconferencing. Written communication could take the form of letters, reports, memos or email. A basic understanding of the nature of the different channels is required, to be able to choose the right channel in any given situation.

Based on three criteria such as whether the communication is oral, written or non-verbal, the level of feedback, and the personal nature of the communication, the communication channels could be classified into the following three types:

- Two-way, face-to-face channels
- Two way, but not face-to-face channels
- One-way, not face-to-face channels

Let us now discuss these channels of communication.

Two-way, face-to-face channels

In this type of communication channel, the communication is oral and non- verbal, immediate feedback is possible, and the communication is of a highly personalised nature.

This type of communication channel could take the form of one-to-one meetings (a superior doing a performance appraisal with an employee), meetings involving small groups of people (board meetings), large gatherings (a speaker making a presentation to a large audience) or video conferences.

Video conferencing requires special rooms equipped with cameras and television screens. Through this, people can see and interact with each other in real-time even if they are located far apart. It also enables participants to share files like spreadsheets and presentations. Organisations use video conferencing to conduct interviews and meetings.

The advantages of using this type of communication channel are:

- Non-verbal communication such as gestures, facial expressions and tone of voice can be used to make communication more effective.

- Immediate feedback is possible in the form of questions, clarifications or suggestions.
- The personal quality of communication is enhanced. This is especially true of one-to-one meetings, where problems and conflicts can be easily resolved.

The disadvantages of this type of communication channel are:

- Difficulty in getting people together and arranging face-to-face meetings.
- Personal meetings are also expensive and time-consuming, especially when people are separated by distances.

Two ways, but not face-to-face channels

With the advent of new technologies, communication can now be two ways, without being face to face, when distance makes such meetings impractical. Teleconferencing, telephone and email communication are all examples of this type of channel.

In this type, the communication is purely oral, since non-verbal cues cannot be used to enhance the communication, in the absence of face-to-face contact. Immediate feedback is, however, possible, as with the face-to-face channel, since the receiver can react immediately to the sender's telephone or email message. The communication which happens through this type of communication channel is of an impersonal nature, due to lack of face-to- face contact.

Teleconferencing is almost as good as face-to-face communication, since it enables two parties in different locations to speak to each other. Today, many large Indian organisations make use of this technology. While teleconferencing has the advantage of saving time and costs involved in travel, it cannot replace face-to-face meetings completely. Some types of interaction such as brainstorming, negotiation, persuasion and problem-solving can be conducted better through face-to-face meetings.

Telephone communication has the advantage of being able to contact people, who would be impossible to reach in person. It is also relatively inexpensive, compared to face-to-face communication. The disadvantage is that it is hard to hold the listener's attention for too long.

Email is another two-way, but not a face-to-face channel that allows senders and receivers to send and respond to one another's messages almost instantaneously. Within an office, email is used as an alternative to telephone communication and personal meetings. Email has the advantage of low cost, speed and the ability to send messages to several people anywhere in the world. The disadvantages are its impersonal nature and the lack of confidentiality, since the messages can be stored or passed on to others.

One-way, not face-to-face channels

All forms of written communication mentioned earlier – letters, reports, memos, notices, etc., may be classified under this type of channel. Written communication is largely one-way communication, since there is usually no instantaneous feedback between the sender and the receiver. It is also purely verbal, since non-verbal communication is not possible, in the absence of face-to-face contact. It lacks the personal quality of face-to-face communication, although it could be personalised to an extent in some forms such as letters.

For example, a sales letter addressed to a customer could be made highly personal, by addressing the customer by name and customising a product to his needs.

4.1. Selecting the Appropriate Channel

Let us now discuss the appropriateness of each of the channels of business communication for different business situations. Although there is no hard and fast rule, the following guidelines would be useful when selecting a channel for a particular situation:

- When trying to solve problems or improve relationships, oral face-to-face communication is generally the most effective form of communication. This is because of the personal nature of face-to-face communication, which makes it more suitable than the other channels of communication.
- When there is a need for visual support in explaining an idea, oral face-to-face communication is the most appropriate channel. For example, highlighting the unique features of a product may require actual product demonstration through face-to-face contact. Explaining a concept may require showing photographs or diagrams through a slide presentation, which is best done face-to-face.
- For making immediate contact, oral face-to-face communication is required. For example, if you want to have the funds in an account released now, you will have to meet a bank manager personally. Putting your request in a letter or through a telephone call may not be of much help.
- When you want to command a high degree of control over the receiver, oral face-to-face communication works best. This is because, as a speaker, you will have greater command over a listener's attention than if you write a letter or a report, which may not be read at all.
- When there is a need for immediate feedback, oral communication, either face-to-face, or non-face-to-face, such as telephone, teleconferencing or email, may be equally appropriate.

Apart from these, the following criteria would justify the need for a one-way, non-face-to-face, communication i.e., written channel:

- When you want the tone of the communication to be formal, written communication is more appropriate than oral communication. For example, communication with the government regarding compliance with tax matters, or with the bank regarding funds for expansion should always be of a highly formal nature, through written letters or reports.
- When you want to explain complicated ideas that require a lot of study and thought by the receiver, written communication is best. For example, explaining the features of a machine is best done through a technical report giving details and technical specifications.
- When you want to convey a large amount of information, written communication is most suitable. It would be difficult to convey this through a lengthy oral presentation, since the speaker would be unable to command a captive audience for too long. The same is true of telephone communication, which should be kept brief. However, it is possible to include many details in a written report that the receiver can read and re-read, at leisure.
- The written channel is also more appropriate when you wish to keep a permanent record of events. For example, the minutes of a business meeting should always be recorded in writing. Written appointment letters should be given to new employees at the time of joining an organization.

4.2. Comparison of Oral and Written Communication Channels

It is evident that oral and written channels both have their relative advantages and disadvantages. This is summarized in table 2.3, which rates each of these channels as 'high' or 'low' on different dimensions.

Table 2: Advantages and Disadvantages of Oral and Written Channels

Characteristic/Dimension	**Oral Communication**	**Written Communication**
Interactivity	High	Low
Level of Feedback	High	Low
Formal Nature	Low	High
Personal Nature	High	Low
Permanent Nature	Low	High
Cost	High	Low

Control over Receiver	High	Low
Effectiveness for Complex Messages	Low	High
Effectiveness for Detailed Messages	Low	High

Communication channels should be selected with care, keeping in mind the requirements of the situation at hand, as well as the inherent advantages and disadvantages of each channel. In some cases, it may be necessary to use a combination of channels, in order to make sure that the message reaches the sender. For example, providing a written research report along with a presentation on findings of a study, or making a follow-up phone call after sending an email message is bound to have more impact and to ensure that the message is well understood.

CASE STUDY

A study conducted by an internal analysis of the small business workplace on ten small businesses located in Melbourne showed that organisational communication is very important for the success of small businesses. The study was conducted through semi-structured interviews and questionnaires.

Table 3 shows the results of the study. This result showed that all participants of small businesses used informal, formal, and active communication both internally and externally to develop a positive environment in the small business workplace:

Table 3: Internal and External Communication

Communication type: Internal	**%**	**Internal comm. Channels**	**%**	**External comm. channels**	**%**
Informal meetings	80	Phone (mobile)	40%	Phone (mobile)	50%
Formal meetings	20	Email/memos	20%	Email	50%
After-hours discussion	70	Face-to-Face	100%	Face-to-face Networking	80%
Social gatherings	50	Phone conferencing	20%	Education	30%

Informal meetings were held more than formal meetings. Many of the small business owners communicated with staff after the meeting hours and during social gatherings. Communication with external environment showed a similar figure. However, half of the owners used email, face-to-face meetings. These figures show the importance of internal/external communication.

(Source: http://www.cric.com.au/seaanz/resources/18BurnettMcMurray.pdf)

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 3

Choose the correct answer:	
9	Identify the communication channel where the communication is oral and non-verbal. a) Two-way, face-to-face channels b) Two ways, but not face-to-face channels c) One-way, not face-to-face channels d) Multiple, but not face-to-face channels
Fill in the Blanks:	
10	_____ enables two parties in different locations to see and speak to each other.
11	When the tone of the communication is to be formal, _____ communication is more appropriate than oral communication.

5. SUMMARY

Let us recapitulate the important concepts discussed in this unit:

- Communication can be divided into two broad areas – verbal and non- verbal communication.
- Verbal communication comprises oral and written communication, which in turn can take many forms in a business context.
- Gestures, facial expressions, posture and the way we dress, are all part of non-verbal communication.
- Although non-verbal communication can affect both our personal and business relationships, it is important in the workplace.
- Oral communication could take place through presentations, meetings or one-to-one meetings, while written communication could be in the form of letters, reports, memos, notices, circulars or email.
- Verbal communication has the disadvantage of being inaccurate or misunderstood, unless the message is carefully worded. Therefore, certain guidelines should be followed when communicating through the oral or written word. It is important to avoid jargon and words that may have multiple meanings and use language that is highly specific, unbiased and inoffensive.
- Non-verbal communication refers to communication without words and plays an important role in business communication.
- Non-verbal communication includes more than just body language. Kinesics, proxemics or personal space and distance, chronemics, paralanguage or tone of voice and physical context are some of the other aspects of non-verbal communication.
- The communication channels may be classified into three types, they are:
    - Two way face-to-face
    - Two-way non-face-to-face
    - One-way non-face-to-face
- If the communication's tone is formal, written communication is more appropriate than oral.
- Written communication is more appropriate to explain complicated ideas that require a lot of study and thought by the receiver and to convey a large amount of information.
- While selecting communication channels, importance should be given to the requirements of the situation at hand, and the inherent advantages and disadvantages of each channel.

6. GLOSSARY

Active communication	-	An effective means of communication in which there is congruence between verbal and non-verbal communication and in which feelings are expressed accurately.
Memo	-	A short message or record used for internal communication in a business.
Performance reviews	-	The process of measuring and analysing the work of an employee.

7. TERMINAL QUESTIONS

1. Explain the different types of verbal communication.
2. Write the advantages of verbal over non-verbal communication.
3. Describe a situation that you experienced where communication went wrong because the non-verbal behaviours sent conflicting signals. Which aspect of non-verbal communication was responsible for the communication failure? How would you rectify this?
4. What is paralanguage? Explain.
5. Name the communication channel to which teleconferencing, Email, and telephone belong to. Explain teleconferencing.

8. ANSWERS

8.1. Self-Assessment Questions

1. Oral, Written / Verbal, Non-verbal
2. Literal translation
3. True
4. False. Verbal communication can be avoided by refusing to speak or write.
5. A – 2, B -3), C - 4), D – 5), E - 1)
6. Leadership
7. Feelings
8. False. Yellow and green are associated with positive feelings.
9. a) Two-way, face-to-face channels
10. Teleconferencing
11. Written

8.2. Terminal Questions Answers

1. There are two types of verbal communication, they are:
   - Oral communication
   - Written communication

   For more details, refer to section 2.

2. Precise words can be used in verbal communication to ensure that the message is clearly understood. But non-verbal communication is not always clear and easy to understand. For more details, refer to sub- section 2.2.

3. Non-verbal behaviours can only express a person's feelings, attitudes, level of interest, likes or dislikes for something. For more details, refer to sub-section 2.2.

4. Para means 'like' or 'similar to', therefore paralanguage means 'like language'. For more details, refer to section 3.

5. Teleconferencing, Email, and telephone belong to 'two way, but not face-to-face channels'. For more details, refer to section 4.

9. CASE STUDY

Improving Dells' Corporate Communication

Many of Dell's participants consider Dell as a very good example of how a company should manage its functionalities and communicate with its participants. Corporate communication must be closely related to a company's overall vision and strategy.

Issue

Dell must align its identity with its image and become independent of technology. If a company depends more on technology, along with bridging the gap between image and identity, it needs to be attentive to technological changes.

Michael Dell, the founder of Dell Computers initiated a primary work environment which depends on e-mail. E-mail can be an effective communication type across time zones. E-mail also helps managers and employees communicate effectively and thereby increases productivity.

However, Dell's increasing dependence on technology-based communication may negatively impact relational development. If Dell's management does not improve the means of communication existing in the company, the company may not grow in a changing corporate environment.

Solution

To improve its communications, Dell's upper management can work more effectively with the departments which communicate with marketing constituencies and create a stronger corporate mission.

The publicity of any product depends on how the marketing department communicates with customers and deals with customers' activities. Increased e-mail dependence can cause information overload for employees. As e-mail is an informal channel of communication, it isolates employees and prevents them from interacting with others. This issue can be solved by adopting face-to-face communications through meetings, team-building activities, and company outings.

Dell should communicate closely with the entities that deal with marketing and involve face-to-face communications within the company. Increased internal and external communication can help Dell to align its image with its identity and help to improve relationships to become a successful company in the changing corporate environment.

Discussion Questions:

1. What is Dell's issue regarding communication? (Hint: Refer 'Issue' section of the case study)
2. What are the advantages and disadvantages of communication through E- mail?
   (Hint: Refer 'Issue' and 'Solution' sections of the case study)

(Source: http://www.slideshare.net/HMueller11/dell-case-study)

10. REFERENCES

- Gamble, T. K. & Gamble, M. (2010). *Communication Works*. 9th ed. New Delhi: Tata McGraw-Hill.

E- References:

- http://www.cric.com.au/seaanz/resources/18BurnettMcMurray.pdf – Retrieved on November 15, 2011.
- http://www.slideshare.net/HMueller11/dell-case-study – Retrieved on November 15, 2011.
- http://changingminds.org/explanations/behaviors/body_language/haptic_ touch.htm – Retrieved on January 9, 2012.
- http://communicationtheory.org/non-verbal-communication/ – Retrieved on January 9, 2012.

Additional Reference:

- Bhatia, R. C. (2009) Business Communication. 2nd ed. New Delhi: Ane Books Pvt. Ltd.